‘Whatever the verdict of history on Nehru may be, either as a leader or as a man, he will remain one of those rare personages who form an inseparable part of their age.’[9] With the benefit of hindsight, we might add a postscript: in India, Nehru forms an inseparable part of any age. Even today, Nehru’s ideas constitute the centre ground in Indian politics and the ideological spectrum is defined by degrees of divergence from them.

Before he came to enjoy this hegemonic power,[10] however, this was not the case; and before his ideas enjoyed the status of received wisdom, they were fiercely contested. Sharing the stage with political and intellectual figures who considered themselves his equals and peers, if not competitors, Nehru had to pit himself vigorously against them in the public realm. In this marketplace of ideas, he had to fend off not only political opponents like Mohammad Ali Jinnah of the All-India Muslim League and Syama Prasad Mookerjee of the Hindu Mahasabha, but also colleagues like the Congress leader Sardar Patel, with whom he often disagreed.

This was a challenge that Nehru took up with gusto. Engaging with them, arguing with them, debating with them and attempting to manipulate them, Nehru fought for his corner, clarifying and structuring his own ideas in the process. In this intellectual combat, he did not even spare Mahatma Gandhi, although he shied away from open confrontation with his mentor. As Gandhi once described to the Viceroy, Lord Linlithgow, after debating his protégé over the Quit India Movement, Nehru had the capacity to argue for days together ‘with a passion that I [Gandhi] have no words to describe’.[11]

Some of the most profound questions in South Asian history were debated this way, many of which continue to remain unresolved, bedevilling the contemporary world as intensely as they did Nehru’s – for example, questions about Muslim representation, about the role of religion in public life, the sanctity and inviolability of Fundamental Rights, or India’s relations with Pakistan and China. Through such sparring – often conducted directly and openly via speeches, correspondence and articles – ideological disagreements were voiced, political allegiances were forged and public opinion was moulded. These hugely consequential debates decisively influenced political events, generating enduring repercussions.